
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

1

Casemiro is thriving under Carrick

Casemiro will [depart Manchester United this summer](#). His four years in English football have been mixed but he may yet go out on a high. At one point in his first season, such as his performance in the [2023 League Cup final](#), he was hailed as the club's best signing since Eric Cantona. He never lived up to that billing, the accusation that United had overpaid for someone who left his legs in Madrid. At the Emirates in 2026, just as against Manchester City the previous week, he showed his muscle memory endures. Kobbie Mainoo is a project player for Michael Carrick. Mainoo can learn much in his remaining months alongside Casemiro, who completed the 90 minutes at Arsenal and retained his influence. United are linked with younger midfielders in Carlos Baleba, Adam Wharton and Elliot Anderson. They may now have something to live up to. **John Brewin**

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Match report: [Arsenal 2-3 Manchester United](#)

2

Arsenal lose their concentration

After months of laser focus, it was a shock to the system to see Arsenal give such an error-strewn performance against [Manchester United](#). They took their eye off the ball the moment they took a first-half lead, twice allowing Bruno Fernandes to get a sight of goal thanks to loose defending before Martín Zubimendi's underhit back pass teed up Bryan Mbeumo to equalise. For Zubimendi, the embodiment of reliability this season, to make such a horrible error summed up Arsenal's day. The second half was a mess of mistimed runs, mis-hit passes and clumsy touches and, while United triumphed thanks to spectacular efforts from Patrick Dorgu and Matheus Cunha, Arsenal's nervous energy was an unwelcome throwback to less convincing seasons. This was their first home defeat of the campaign, the first time they have conceded three goals in a game in more than two years, their only loss this season after going ahead and a first league defeat to United at home since 2017. With Arsenal's lead at the top trimmed to four points, there is no time for navel-gazing. They have to put things right next weekend at Leeds. **Will Magee**

3

Newcastle are short of creativity

Unai Emery came over all coy in the face of suggestions that his [Aston Villa](#) side might be title contenders but Eddie Howe was left to reflect on the consequences of Sunday's damaging 2-0 home defeat to Aston Villa. Newcastle's manager was asked if he lacked a creator of the quality of Morgan Rogers or Emi Buendía and he did not demur. "I think when you lose like we did today, there's a valid argument for everything," said Howe, who invested the best part of £180m in the attacking skills of Nick Woltemade, Yoane Wissa and Anthony Elanga last summer. "Everyone wants to change something. But we have the players that we have, and we have to find a solution with those players. There's no point me thinking we need another type of player at this moment because it's not going to happen. The next chance we'll really have to change the squad will be the summer. It's about getting the best out of the players we have." Over to you Eddie. How about deploying Woltemade as a No 10? **Louise Taylor**

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Match report: [Newcastle 0-2 Aston Villa](#)

Kolo Muani is not trusted at Spurs

When Tottenham were chasing the game against Burnley, Thomas Frank was wondering how to change things with substitutions. Amid injury problems, his options were limited but he had Randal Kolo Muani available, the 27-year-old striker with 31 France caps and nine international goals to his name, making him almost perfect in a difficult moment. Such has been the lamentable nature of his loan spell that has accrued zero goals in 15 [Premier League](#) appearances, Frank left him sitting in the freezing Lancashire cold. If he is not deemed suitable in these moments, then keeping him on the books seems pointless for player and club. Freeing up his wages by sending him back to Paris Saint-Germain would be helpful in the transfer market. Kolo Muani's only hope of turning things around in England looks like a change in head coach, which isn't too far-fetched, but like Frank, he does not have the backing of the fans. **Will Unwin**

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Match report: [Burnley 2-2 Tottenham](#)

Guéhi settles in nicely at City

Marc Guéhi's Manchester City debut ended with him being embraced by Nico O'Reilly, after the centre-back denied Wolves a late strike, ensured a clean sheet, and showed a firm bond already with his new side. The defender's [£20m move from Crystal Palace](#) came, in part, after advice from two England and now City team-mates. "Yeah – Phil Foden and John Stones, conversations with the manager, conversations with Hugo Viana [the director of football]," he said. One colleague who may leave in the summer is Bernardo Silva, according to Pep Guardiola. "We spoke a lot with Bernie and Bernie has to decide the best for him, his family. Whatever happens he will remain one of the greatest players of this club." **Jamie Jackson**

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Match report: [Manchester City 2-0 Wolves](#)

Palace throw Canvot in the deep end

Crystal Palace have enjoyed success from their policy of developing potential but the case of Jaydee Canvot shows how risky that can be. The 19-year-old joined in the summer for big money, having only recently made his breakthrough into Toulouse's first team, and has found himself thrown in at the deep end after Marc Guéhi was sold to [Manchester City](#). A poor back pass gifted Chelsea their opening goal in Sunday's disappointing defeat that made it 11 games without a win in all competitions for Palace. Canvot also gave away a penalty and was taken off. The French defender needs more time to develop away from the spotlight and Oliver Glasner will be relieved to have Chadi Riad back in contention after a long-term knee injury, although another experienced defender has to be a priority this month if Palace are to stop their slide. **Ed Aarons**

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Match report: [Crystal Palace 1-3 Chelsea](#)

Wilson and Silva keep stumm

With 17 goal involvements in 17 games for club and country since the start of November, Harry Wilson is, as his manager Marco Silva said, "in the best moment of his career". No Premier League player is outperforming xG as strongly as the Welshman. Wilson's talent has been apparent since his time in the [Liverpool](#) academy, his shooting prowess always his strongest suit. At 28, now an experienced senior player, consistency is being paired with ability. He is supplying his trademark spectacular goals on a regular basis. His stoppage-time free-kick rubbed out a decent performance for Brighton – the visitors' defeat was, in Silva's view, "harsh". Wilson's Fulham contract expires in June and he is reported to be waiting on Silva's decision on his own future. Silva, a candidate for the Tottenham job that went to Thomas Frank last summer, is keeping his intentions to himself, though he has not hidden his disappointment at Fulham's lack of spending. Craven Cottage would sorely miss both player and manager. **JB**

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Match report: [Fulham 2-1 Brighton](#)

Dyche takes aims at ... towels?

Sean Dyche declared a war on towels after Forest's win at [Brentford](#). "Why don't the Premier League go: 'No towels, just get on with the game?'" he said. "Just say no towels. Dead easy, isn't it? Not rocket science, you know? Why make it more complicated?" Spectators frustrated by this season's many delays and interruptions, including the endless wiping of balls before long throws, might be inclined to agree. But it should be observed that Dyche was not accusing his opponents on the day of being pro-towel, and there were no towels in use at the Gtech Stadium. Dyche's crusade against time-wasting was most likely a traditional case of deflection. Brentford's support were on at Forest players for time-wasting from the start of Sunday's match and Keith Andrews afterwards accused Forest of taking "an eternity" with every restart, something Dyche did not deny. "All managers will use whatever they can to their advantage", the Forest manager admitted. "That's the way it is." **Paul MacInnes**

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Match report: [Brentford 0-2 Nottingham Forest](#)

Hill rises to Liverpool challenge

Just as it seemed Bournemouth may have sold one player too many and with the threat of being dragged into a relegation fight looming large, Andoni Iraola's side turned in a typically fearless performance to topple the champions. [Antoine Semenyo's £62.5m record sale to Manchester City](#) this month means, across the past seven months, the Cherries have sold three players to the past three winners of the Champions League, plus Milos Kerkez to Liverpool. Adrien Truffert, Kerkez's replacement from Rennes, negated Mohamed Salah but arguably Bournemouth's best performer was James Hill, another star in the making. The 24-year-old was outstanding in defence but also set up his team's second goal and it was his long throw that led to Amine Adli's winner. A £1m buy from Fleetwood Town amid interest from Barcelona in 2022, Hill has seized his opportunity, shining as a No 6, right-back and at centre-back and keeping £34m signing Bafodé Diakité out of the team. **Ben Fisher**

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Match report: [Bournemouth 3-2 Liverpool](#)

Does Paquetá's exit suit all parties?

Nuno Espírito Santo talks about rebalancing West Ham's squad. Niclas Füllkrug, Luis Guilherme, Callum Marshall, Andy Irving and George Eardley have left the club this month. Guido Rodríguez is on his way to Valencia, underlining the wasted money at West Ham down the years. The biggest question, though, remains how the Lucas Paquetá situation plays out. He wants to return to Brazil to play for Flamengo but West Ham are reluctant sellers. They fear that losing the Brazilian now would hurt their push to stay up. However, Paquetá's absence with a minor back problem has coincided with West Ham winning their past three games. Nuno needs players who want to be there. West Ham are in a fight and need absolute commitment. Nuno expects Paquetá to play for the club again. However, West Ham need to work out if there is any benefit to making the midfielder stay. **Jacob Steinberg**

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Match report: [West Ham 3-1 Sunderland](#)

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	23	25	50
2	Man City	23	26	46
3	Aston Villa	23	10	46
4	Man Utd	23	7	38
5	Chelsea	23	14	37
6	Liverpool	23	3	36
7	Fulham	23	0	34
8	Brentford	23	3	33
9	Newcastle	23	3	33
10	Sunderland	23	-2	33
11	Everton	22	-1	32
12	Brighton	23	2	30
13	AFC Bournemouth	23	-5	30
14	Tottenham Hotspur	23	2	28
15	Crystal Palace	23	-4	28
16	Leeds	22	-7	25
17	Nottm Forest	23	-11	25
18	West Ham	23	-18	20
19	Burnley	23	-19	15
20	Wolverhampton	23	-28	8

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